



Dak Guru

A Self Learning Portal

www.dakguru.com

Service Discharge Benefit Scheme

DISCLAIMER: *This booklet has been prepared strictly from an examination point of view. While every effort has been made to ensure accuracy and the inclusion of recent changes, amendments, and updates to the relevant Acts, Rules, and Regulations, this document is intended as a study aid only. Readers and students are strongly recommended to refer to official government sources or gazettes for the most reliable and authoritative information.*

Service Discharge Benefit Scheme

Introduction and Preamble

The Gramin Dak Sevak Committee, headed by Shri R. S. Nataraja Murti, Retired Member of the Postal Services Board, in its Report (October, 2008), had inter alia recommended the introduction of a Service Discharge Benefit Scheme, in place of the existing Severance Amount scheme, on an optional basis for the Gramin Dak Sevaks. The Government has examined the recommendations in consultation with the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) and accepted the recommendations of the Committee.

The Government, therefore, decided to introduce a new Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS) with effect from **1st April, 2011**. The new Scheme is based on the NPS-Lite Scheme, 2010, introduced by PFRDA for the workers' groups of unorganized sector, small investors, and all Citizens of India with certain modifications in order to suit the requirements of the Department as well as the Gramin Dak Sevaks (GDS). The scheme shall utilize the platform of NPS-Lite Scheme for the purpose of registration, record keeping, funds management, etc., in accordance with the relevant Rules and Regulations/instructions issued from time to time by the PFRDA, Security and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), Reserve Bank of India (RBI), Ministry of Finance, Government of India in this regard.

Part I - Introductory

1. The Scheme

- (a) The scheme shall be called the "Service Discharge Benefit Scheme", hereinafter mentioned as the "SDBS".
- (b) The scheme shall come into effect with effect from the **1st day of the month of April, 2011**.

2. Definitions

In these regulations, unless the context otherwise requires:

- (a) "**Accumulations**" means the total/aggregate amount available in a Permanent Retirement Account of a beneficiary/subscriber plus the accrued severance amount, if any, from the date of appointment to the date of enrollment of a GDS beneficiary in SDBS at a given point of time.
- (b) "**Aggregator-Cum-Accounts Office**" (AO), for the purpose of SDBS, means an office of General Manager (Postal Accounts and Finance) and/or the office of Director of Accounts (Postal), also known as Circle/Postal Accounts Offices (C/AO) of the Department of Posts.
- (c) "**GDS Beneficiary/Subscriber**" means the Gramin Dak Sewak, who has been enrolled under the Scheme.

(d) "**Annuity/Life Annuity**" means the Annuity Scheme of a Life Insurance Company, approved by Insurance Regulatory & Development Authority to be purchased mandatorily by the subscriber/beneficiary at the time of exit from the scheme.

(e) "**Collection Centre**" (CC), for the purpose of SDBS, means an Office of Director, Senior/Superintendent of Post Offices/Head of a Postal Division in the Department of Posts.

(f) "**CRA**" means the Central Record Keeping Agency, appointed by the PFRDA to keep and maintain individual records and data of each and every Subscriber/beneficiary under the NPS-Lite as well as SDBS.

(g) "**Custodian**" means a company/agency, responsible for holding assets of the NPS Trust; presently the Stockholding Corporation of India Limited (SCIL).

(h) "**Department**" means the Department of Posts, New Delhi.

(i) "**Depository Account**" means the account opened, maintained and operated by the Portfolio/Fund Managers with any Depository or Depository Participant registered under the SEBI (Depositories and Participants) Regulations, 1996, which shall exclusively deal with the Portfolio of the SDBS.

(j) "**Director General (Posts)**" means the Director General, Department of Posts, of the Central Government who is also the Chairperson of the Postal Services Board and Ex-officio Secretary to the Government of India.

(k) "**Divisional Head**" means the head of a Postal Division viz: Director, Senior/Superintendent of Post Offices (Dir./SSPOS/SPOS.).

(l) "**Facilitation Centre**" means a Facilitation Centre of the Central Record Keeping Agency (CRA), functioning anywhere in the country.

(m) "**Gramin Dak Sevak (GDS)**" means the Gramin Dak Sevaks engaged in various offices in the Department of Posts on regular basis in accordance with the **Gramin Dak Sevaks (Conduct and Engagement) Rules, 2020**, as amended from time to time.

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Substituted for "GDS (Conduct and Employment) Rules, 2001" to reflect the current statutory rules governing GDS engagement. (Updated 2025).

(n) "**New Pension Scheme (NPS)**" means the New Pension Scheme, introduced by the Ministry of Finance, Department of Economic Affairs, and regulated by the PFRDA, for the Central Government Departmental Employees.

(o) "**NPS-Lite**" means the NPS-Lite Pension Scheme, launched as an initiative of the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) of India for the benefit of senior citizens, small investors and workers in the unorganized Sector, vide PFRDA's NPS-Lite Office document, issued under National Pension System (NPS).

(p) "**NPS Trust**" means the New Pension System Trust, established by PFRDA under Indian Trust Act, 1882, which will administer the "National Pension System".

(q) "**Oversight Office**" (**OO**), for the purpose of SDBS, means the Office of Director General, Department of Posts, New Delhi.

(r) "**PFRDA**" means the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority of India.

(s) "**Pension Fund Manager (PFM)**" means the company and/or agency appointed by PFRDA to render Fund management services for management of the Funds under various Pension Fund Schemes including SDBS, as per laid down terms and conditions.

(t) "**PRA**" means the Permanent Retirement Account, to be opened by the CRA in respect of each GDS beneficiary/subscriber under the SDBS.

(u) "**PRAN**" means the Permanent Retirement Account Number, to be allotted by the CRA to each GDS beneficiary/subscriber under the SDBS.

(v) "**Savings Bank Account**" means the accounts opened under the Post Office Savings Account scheme, in the concerned Post office by the Gramin Dak Sevak for the purpose of the SBDS.

(w) "**Severance Amount**" means the amount payable to the Gramin Dak Sevaks, at the time of end of their engagement with the Department, subject to the terms and conditions prescribed for this purpose.

(x) "**Trustee Bank**" means the Bank(s) designated by the NPS Trust/PFRDA for receiving and holding the funds and maintaining account(s) therefor in respect of the SDBS.

(y) The words/phrases/abbreviations, which are not defined here in this scheme, shall have the same meaning and interpretation as provided for in the NPS-Lite Scheme, unless otherwise provided for in the Scheme.

3. Eligibility to Join

(a) Existing Gramin Dak Sevaks

- (i) All existing regularly engaged Gramin Dak Sevaks, who have been selected after due process in accordance with the **Gramin Dak Sevaks (Conduct and Engagement) Rules, 2020**, and rendered at least **one year's** satisfactory service, subject to the provisions contained in clauses (ii) to (iv) below, are eligible to join the scheme.

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Reference updated to "Rules, 2020" to align with current regulations.

- (ii) The existing Gramin Dak Sevaks, who are due to be discharged from service within **3 years** as on **01st January, 2011**, shall not be eligible to join the scheme.

- **(iii) OPTION:** The existing regularly engaged Gramin Dak Sevaks on the date of notification of the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS), shall exercise an option, in the prescribed proforma: SDBS-8, either to switch over to the new Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS) or to continue in the existing Severance Amount scheme.
 - **NOTE:** The existing Gramin Dak Sevaks, opting to continue to remain under the Severance Amount scheme, shall continue to be subject to the existing terms and conditions of that scheme, without any linkage whatsoever, to the SDBS.
- **(iv)(1)** In case of the Gramin Dak Sevaks, opting to join the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS), the Severance amount accrued till the date of their joining the scheme, @ Rs. 1,500 for every completed year of service till their enrolment under SDBS, will be added to the accumulated contributions in their Permanent Retirement Account at the time of Discharge from service/death for annuitisation/utilization in accordance with these regulations.
- **(iv)(2)** The amount of severance amount for the period less than a year shall be calculated for the completed months on proportionate basis. The fraction period of less than **15 days** shall be ignored, while the period of **15 days** or more shall be treated as a complete month for the purpose.
- **(v) GDS in RMS UNITS:** For the Gramin Dak Sevaks (Mailmen, etc.) working in the Railway Mail Service (RMS) units, the options from the existing GDS will be obtained by the concerned Divisional Head (Director/Sr./ Superintendent of RMS) and the applications in prescribed NLS1 proforma, after due authorization/verification shall be sent to the neighbouring Postal Divisions to which their units are tagged for the purpose of registration, generation of PRAN, etc..

(b) Newly Appointed GDS

- **(i)** The Scheme shall be mandatorily applicable to all the Gramin Dak Sevaks, engaged on a regular basis under the prescribed **Gramin Dak Sevaks (Conduct and Engagement) Rules, 2020** on or after introduction of the Scheme; on completing **one year** of satisfactory service.
- **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Reference updated to "Rules, 2020".
- **(ii)** These new entrant Gramin Dak Sevaks shall not have any option in this regard and, hence, they shall not be eligible/entitled to any benefit(s) under the Severance Amount Scheme, in any case.
- (c)** The provisionally engaged GDS and substitutes engaged for short term vacancy/ies, leave periods, etc., in absence of the regular GDS, are not eligible for joining the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS).

4. Subscription

(a) Subject to the provisions contained in sub-para (2) below, the Government of India, Department of Posts, shall subscribe @ Rs. 300 per month for which they have drawn their Time Related Continuity Allowance for each Gramin Dak Sevak, enrolled under the SDBS. The Gramin Dak Sevaks shall not be required to make any contribution from their side under the scheme. The contributions made by the Department shall be deposited with the Trustee Bank, designated by the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) and invested through Pension Fund Managers (PFMs) designated by the PFRDA.

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Substituted for "Rs. 200" vide Department of Posts Order No. 6-11/2009-PE.II dated 17.11.2016, effective from 01.01.2016.

(b) No contribution/subscription shall be made by the Department in respect of the Gramin Dak Sevaks, during the period they are placed on 'Put off duty' or remain unauthorisedly absent from duty. In other words, the contribution will not be made, for such beneficiaries, for whom the TRCA is not drawn by Drawing and Disbursing officers.

5. Appointment / Permanent Absorption of a GDS in a Regular Departmental Post

The Gramin Dak Sevaks, who are enrolled under the Scheme, and subsequently permanently absorbed/appointed in the Department against a regular Departmental post, shall be required to quit the Scheme immediately and to seek transfer of the accrued accumulations in their PR Account under the SDBS as well as accrued severance amount, earned till their date of such absorption/regular appointment, to their new account under the New Pension Scheme, already in operation for Central Government, Departmental employees, for which he/she will become eligible on such regular appointment. Such transferred funds/accumulations shall then be regulated, invested and managed under the New Pension Scheme, for the Central Government employees, as amended from time to time. Application for the purpose shall be submitted in prescribed form SDBS-1.

NOTE: Similar will be the situation in case of a GDS having been appointed to a regular post under the Central Government or "the State Government/Organisation where the New Pension System has been implemented on Central Government's pattern". Provisions contained in case of resignation from service as contained in para 11(d) below shall apply in case of others.

6. Scheme Preferences

The GDS beneficiaries under this scheme will have a common scheme preference and the Pension Fund Managers, chosen by Department of Posts. The Annuity Provider will also be selected by Department of Posts in consultation with PFRDA. Changes, if any, in the scheme preferences and switchover instructions will be considered and decided by the Department, from time to time.

NOTE: For the present, the Department has opted for investments as per Central Government scheme preferences. The investment shall also be made across the three Pension Fund Managers, in the ratio as decided by PFRDA/ NPS Trust.

7. Nodal Agency

The Pension Fund Regulatory Development Authority (PFRDA) is the Nodal Agency and Central Record Keeping Agency (CRA) appointed by the PFRDA will maintain the data/records as well as upload/transmit the data to the Trustee Bank advising it (the Trustee Bank) to transfer the funds to the relevant Pension Fund Manager (PFM) for investment purposes. At present the National Security Depository Limited Mumbai is the designed CRA for PFRDA for this scheme.

Part II - Operating Procedure

8. Enrolment and Assigning Permanent Retirement Account Number (PRAN)

(a) The Gramin Dak Sevaks opting to come under the SBDS, shall have to submit an application in the prescribed proforma (NLS1) for their enrolment in the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS). Such applications for enrolment will be sent to the **Collection Centers** (Postal Divisional office) concerned by the Sub Divisional Inspector/ASPOs., duly attested and verified as required. The Collection Centers will collect all such applications, ensure that the applications are complete in all respects and forward them to the relevant **Facilitation Centers** of the Central Record Keeping Agency (CRA) for enrollment after due verification and attestation of the details and issue of digitised card containing inter alia **Permanent Retirement Account Number (PRAN)** for the Gramin Dak Sevak concerned. The list of Facilitation Centres of Central Record Keeping Agency (CRA) where the applications of Gramin Dak Sevaks opted to join the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS); will be sent, shall be circulated to all concerned from time to time.

(b) The Gramin Dak Sevaks opting for enrollment under the SDBS, shall also be required to open a **Savings Bank Account** in the concerned Post Office and the particulars of such SB Account shall be furnished in the relevant columns of the application form by the GDS. The account shall be kept live throughout the service period as also thereafter, for transfer/credit of monthly annuity amounts on exit from the Scheme.

(c) On receipt of applications in prescribed format, duly completed and verified by the Head of the Collection Centre (Dir./S/SPOs.), the CRA shall enroll the applicant GDS as subscribers/beneficiaries under the SDBS, open a Permanent Retirement Account, issue digitized **PRAN CARD** in respect of each GDS beneficiary/subscriber and send the same to the concerned Collection Centre for their onward transmission and delivery to the concerned GDS under acknowledgement.

(d) The Collection Centre shall maintain a register of the GDS, applied for enrollment under SDBS, in the prescribed form (**SDBS-2**) appended hereto, mentioning the particulars of the GDS, viz: name, designation, office of working, PRAN*, etc., and keep it updated from time to time. This register shall be kept as a permanent record.

*: to be entered on receipt from CRA.

(e) The Collection Centre shall also, for the first time, prepare a list of all such GDS, enrolled under SDBS, mentioning the particulars of the GDS, viz: name, designation, office of working, PRAN, etc., in the prescribed form (**SDBS-3**), appended hereto, and send the same to the concerned "Head Post Office (HPO) in the case of GDS working in post offices" and "Head Record Office (HRO) in case of GDS working in Railway Mail Service" Units, who is disbursing the Time Related Continuity Allowances to the GDS as well as to the **Aggregator cum Accounts Office (AO)** for their information and record. The Collection Centres shall, thereafter, continue to send supplementary lists in respect of the new GDS enrolled during the month by the **5th** of the following month to the HPO/HRO and AO on a monthly basis in order to enable them to keep their records updated. For a month, when there is no enrollment, 'NIL' lists shall be sent to all concerned by the Collection Centre by the stipulated date.

(f) The HPO/HRO and AO shall also maintain the register (in form: **SDBS-2**) mentioned in sub-para-4 above and keep it updated with the Lists/supplementary lists received by them from the Collection Centres for their reference and record. They shall also keep these lists safely in guard files for their information and reference, as a permanent record.

(g) **Duplicate PRAN Card:** In case of loss of the Digital PRAN Card, the GDS shall make an application to CRA on the form prescribed by PFRDA/CRA, mentioning his all particulars, PRAN, etc., which were mentioned in the PRAN Card and send the same to the Collection Centre, along with a proof of loss of the original card and a Duplicate PRAN Card issue fee of **Rs. 20/=** (twenty only) for the first time and **Rs. 30/=** (thirty only) for subsequent occasions. The fee shall be deposited by the GDS subscriber at any post office in India where the same shall be treated as Unclassified Receipt (UCR)- Fee for re-issue of PRAN Card. The AO shall classify and book the same under the concerned head of account mentioned in **Part-III: Accounting Procedure**. The Collection Centre, after verifying the particulars and enclosures, forward the application to the Facilitation Centre of CRA for issue of the duplicate card by the CRA and sending the same to the subscriber/beneficiary through Collection Centre. Collection Centre shall ensure its delivery to the beneficiary under receipt. The fee received shall be netted against the management expenses for SDBScheme.

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** While the text prescribes Rs. 20/30, PFRDA/CRA charges for reprint of PRAN cards are subject to revision by the Authority. Current PFRDA rates may vary.

9. Subscription & Process

(a) Every month, the HPO/HRO concerned shall prepare a subscription list in form (**SDBS-4**) of the Gramin Dak Sevaks, working under their accounts jurisdiction, enrolled under SDBS for whom the Time Related Continuity Allowance is drawn and eligible to subscribe under the scheme for the month, and shall send the same to the Aggregator-Cum-Accounts Office (AO) with a copy to the Collection Centre by the **5th** of the following month positively both in the shape of Soft copy and a hard copy. The AO, on authorization by the CRA, shall also upload the soft data into the CRA's profile in order to update the data already available with the CRA.

(b) Simultaneously, the Head Post Office/Head Record Office concerned, shall with the help of the list mentioned in sub para (1) above, shall prepare Subscription Bill of the Gramin Dak Sevaks enrolled under the SDBS for drawl of subscription towards SDBS at the rate of **Rs. 300/=** (rupees three hundred only) per month per GDS and forward the same to the concerned AO alongwith the monthly Cash Accounts Return. After due verification, the Collection Centre will send a verified copy to the AO as well as the Head Post Office/Head Record Office in token of having verified and correctness.

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Substituted for "Rs. 200" vide Department of Posts O.M. No. 17-31/2016-GDS dated 27.06.2018, effective from 01.07.2018.

(c) The AO, on receipt of the lists from HPOs. and HROs., shall verify the particulars of the GDS from the Register maintained at their end, shall prepare a consolidated list of the GDS, in Form **SDBS-5**, received from all the HPOs./HROs., verify the same with reference to the Subscription Bills, received alongwith the monthly cash accounts of various HOs. And HROs., under its accounts jurisdiction and prepare a cheque for a total amount of **Rs. 300/=** (rupees three hundred only) per GDS subscriber/beneficiary, charge the same to the relevant functional head of account and remit the Cheque alongwith the list to the designated Trustee Bank. A copy of the List shall simultaneously be sent by the AO to the CRA for their information, and for updating their records and other necessary action.

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Substituted for "Rs. 200" to align with the enhanced contribution rate effective 01.07.2018.

(d) On authorization from the CRA, the Trustee Bank will transfer the funds to the designated Pension Fund Managers for investment in accordance with the instructions of the Government/Department of Posts.

(e) Should any error and/or irregularity/ies is/are noticed by any of the CC, HPO/HRO, or AO in any of the lists, bills, information received by them, the same shall be noted in the **register of Errors/Objections**, to be maintained by them for the purpose and taken up with the relevant office immediately in order to have the same corrected/settled within reasonable time frame. The register shall be reviewed by the Head/Incharge of the concerned office once a month atleast, who shall ensure that no error or irregularity remains pending for more than a month from the date it has coming to

notice. The error or irregularity pending for more than a month should be reported to the Head of Circle concerned who in turn shall take up suitable steps to sort it out immediately.

(f) The severance amount accrued to each of the "GDS enrolled under the Scheme", from the date of initial engagement to the date of enrollment, shall be "calculated by the HPO/HRO/DDO concerned, verified by the Collection Centre/Head of Unit concerned and pre-checked by the AO (AO), noted in the relevant column of the Register (**SDBS-2**) by all concerned under dated initials of the Head Postmaster / Head Record Officer / Head of Office/Unit concerned. This amount shall be taken into account for arriving at the share of accumulations/amounts (the net accretions under SDBS plus the accrued severance amount) to be annuitized as well as released in cash to the GDS beneficiary at the time of exit from the scheme/death, as the case may be.

10. Management and Utilisation of Funds

The funds accumulated under the SDBS Scheme, shall be administered by the **NPS Trust** and invested by the Pension Fund Managers (PFM) as per Investment Management Agreement (IMA) entered into between the NPS Trust and PFMs.

11. Exit from the (SDBS)

(a) At the time of discharge of his/her services from the Department on attaining the age of normal discharge, the outgoing Gramin Dak Sevak would be required to invest a minimum of **40%** of accumulations to purchase a life annuity from any authorized Life Insurance Company, duly approved by the Insurance Regulatory & Development Authority (IRDA). However, the outgoing GDS shall be free to purchase a life annuity even for a sum exceeding **40%** of their accumulations in the fund. The Life Insurance Company shall pay a suitable amount of monthly return to the Discharged GDS and his/her spouse during their remaining life time based on the terms and conditions of investment. Application shall be submitted in form **SDBS-6**.

(b) The remaining amount i.e. **60%** of the accumulations shall be paid to the discharged GDS in lump sum, which may be utilised by him/her as per their own will and discretion.

(c) **PREMATURE EXIT.**— A Gramin Dak Sevak, if he/she so wishes can withdraw at any point of time after attaining the age of **58 years**, an amount not exceeding **20%** of the accumulations in his/her PRA, leaving the balance **80%** to be withdrawn at the time of exit from the Scheme on completion of his services as GDS. But in such a case, the entire **80%** of the accumulations shall be required to be invested to purchase a Life Annuity from the authorized Life Insurance Company, as referred to in sub para (1) above. The Department shall not make any contributions for such beneficiaries from the date of their premature withdrawal after attaining the age of **58 years**. Application shall be submitted in form **SDBS-6**.

(d) **RESIGNATION FROM SERVICE** — Subject to the provisions contained in para 5 of these regulations, a Gramin Dak Sevak opted to join the SDBS scheme and resigns from service before

normal exit, the PR Account of such GDS shall be treated as closed on the date of acceptance of his/her resignation and all the accumulations at his/her credit on the date of his/her acceptance of his resignation shall be withdrawn and the resigning GDS shall have to invest **80%** (eighty per cent) of the accumulations to purchase an Annuity from the Authorised Life Insurance Company, as referred to in sub para (a) above. Only **20%** of the accumulations shall be paid to him/her as lump sum amount. Application shall be submitted in form **SDBS-6**.

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** Substituted for "85%" and "15%" respectively. Pursuant to PFRDA (Exits and Withdrawals under the National Pension System) Amendment Regulations, 2025, notified December 2025, resignation from the Government sector requires mandatory annuitization of at least 80% of the accumulated pension wealth, with a maximum of 20% available as lump sum (unless the total corpus is ≤ Rs. 5 Lakhs).

(e) At the time of exit and/or making premature withdrawal from the scheme, the beneficiary, shall have to submit an application through Collection Center to the Central Record Keeping Agency for settlement of his/her dues/accumulations in the Permanent Retirement Account (PRA) in the Form **SDBS-6**. The CRA shall calculate the dues/accumulations and settle the claim in accordance with these Regulations, release amounts for investments on behalf of the holder of PRA, of the percentage of the accumulations to purchase an Annuity in favour of the holder of Account, and make payments of the residual / sums to the applicant concerned through the Collection Centres (CC), under intimation to the AO.

12. Death while in Service

(a) In the event of death of Gramin Dak Sevaks while in service, the nominee(s)/legal heir(s) will have an option either to receive the entire accumulations in the late GDS's PRA till the day of death, as lump sum, or to continue to be enrolled under the scheme, if they so desire. In that case, he or she (the nominee/Legal Heir) will have to subscribe to the scheme personally from their own pocket, after following the Know Your Customer (KYC) procedure and the Government shall bear no responsibility and/or have any liability, whatsoever, for making further contributions, etc., to the scheme on behalf of such deceased Gramin Dak Sevak or to the payment of any accumulated/exit value to such nominee(s)/legal heir(s).

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** The option to receive "entire accumulations... as lump sum" is subject to PFRDA Exit Regulations. As of the 2025 Amendments, full lump sum withdrawal is typically permitted only if the total corpus is ≤ Rs. 5 Lakhs. For corpus > Rs. 5 Lakhs, PFRDA regulations generally mandate 80% Annuitization for death claims in the Government sector/NPS-Lite.

(b) The PR Account, so continued and operated by the nominees/legal heirs of the deceased Gramin Dak Sevaks, as per sub para (1) above, shall continue till the month by which the deceased Gramin Dak Sevak could have attained the age of normal discharge (**65 years** at present), after which **40 per cent** of the accumulated balance available in the PRA shall be required to be invested in an annuity

scheme and **60 per cent** thereof shall be paid to the nominee/legal heir(s) for utilization as per their discretion as is done in the case of a GDS being discharged from his engagement with the department on completion of the normal age of such engagement.

13. Dismissal/Removal from Service

(a) **DISMISSAL/REMOVAL FROM SERVICE.**— In the case of a Gramin Dak Sevak, being dismissed and/or removed from service as a result of a penal action/disciplinary proceedings, he/she shall cease to be a member of SDBS and shall automatically forfeit his past service from the date of such dismissal/removal and he/she will have no claim, whatsoever, in respect of the accumulations in his/her account under SDBS. Such Account shall be closed immediately, the accumulations in such account shall devolve on the Government/Department of Posts, and accordingly payable to the Department for crediting to the Central Government's account.

(b) **REINSTATEMENT IN SERVICE.**— In the case of a dismissed/removed from service Gramin Dak Sevak is reinstated in service by any of the Appellate, Revisionary authority/ies or by a Court order and completely exonerated of the charges leveled against him/her and also the period of 'Put off duty' is treated to be as service, such GDS shall be deemed to have been continuing as a Member of the scheme and necessary/accumulated subscription for such period treated as duty, shall be contributed/paid by the Department at normal rate.

14. Registration

(a) **Collection Centre.** All the Heads of Postal Divisions shall enroll themselves as Collection Centres (NL CC) and for the purpose every Postal Division shall submit an application form in the prescribed format (NL N3) for registration with Central Record Keeping Agency (CRA) appointed by the Pension Fund Regulatory Development Authority (PFRDA). The Divisional Head shall send their applications for registration to concerned AO for attestation and further necessary action.

(b) **Accounts Office.**—The Director of Accounts Postal of the Circles, designated as AOs., are also required to register themselves as Accounts Office (NL AO) by submitting an application in the prescribed form (NL N2). This application form along with the applications for registration as Collection Centres (NLCC), received from Senior/Superintendents of Post offices; after due attestation, shall be submitted to the Oversight Office/Postal Directorate(NL OO).

(c) **Oversight Office.**— The Postal Directorate, functioning as Oversight Office (OO) for the purpose of this scheme, will register itself with the Central Record Keeping Agency (CRA) by submitting an application in form (NL N1). The applications of Collection Centres (NLCC) and Accounts Offices (NLAO) shall be consolidated in the Oversight Office (OO) and sent to the Central Record Keeping Agency (CRA) for the purpose of registration.

(d)(i) The Heads of Circles (CO) as well as Regional Postmasters General/Directors of Postal Services (RO) Shall assist the Postal Directorate (OO) in its overseeing functions and periodical monitoring as

well as settlement of errors/irregularities, redressal of grievances, from time to time. The Head Of Circle/Regional Office shall be responsible to ensure that all steps and actions/responsibilities devolved on the Divisional/Sub Divisional Heads, HPOs. and HROs., in their Circles/Regions, are appropriately performed/borne by them in accordance with these regulations as well as various instructions issued by Oversight Office in this regard from time to time, are followed in letter and spirit by them.

(ii) Director Postal Services(HQs.) in all Circles as well as Regional Offices shall function as a Nodal Officer for their Circle/Region, to coordinate between the Collection Centres, HPOs./HROs., CRA and its Facilitating Centers situated in their areas, as well as the Oversight Office (Postal Directorate).

(e) The Heads of Circle shall also issue necessary orders to tag the RMS Units in their Circle with the adjacent Postal Division for the purpose of the scheme.

15. Payments of Various Charges

The cost of enrollment/preparation of digitized cards, Annual Servicing Charges, subscriber servicing, grievance handling and settlement, uploading of subscribers' data/MIS, etc., in respect of the Permanent Retirement Accounts of the enrolled Gramin Dak Sevaks under the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS), shall be borne by the Department.

15-A. CRA, etc., shall raise necessary claim bills in this regard, annually, during the month of April, proceeding the year of the claim bill, and submit the same to the concerned Aggregator-cum-Accounts Office (AO) concerned. The AO, after carrying out necessary checks and verification of the correctness of the claim(s), shall make payments, charging the amount(s) to the relevant head of account prescribed in Para-24, **Part-III-Accounting Procedure**, of these Regulations, and met from the relevant year's sanctioned grants.

16. Inspection of Documents/Records

The accounts, records, documents, maintained and held in the concerned offices of the Department shall be subject to inspections, checks and/or verification by the Officers of the Department of Posts, Internal Audit, Statutory Audit, etc., as per the procedures and norms prescribed in this regard by the Central Government, Comptroller and Auditor General of India, etc.

17. Failure to Submit Option

(a) If any of the Gramin Dak Sevaks fails to submit his/her option by the specified date, circulated separately, such GDS shall be deemed to have opted to continue in the existing Severance Amount scheme. Option, once exercised, shall be final and cannot be revised at a later date.

(b) As provided in para 3(2), the newly appointed Gramin Dak Sevaks, on or after the **1st January, 2011**, shall have no such option to continue under Severance Amount scheme or switch over to the

SDBS, as they shall be enrolled under SDBS mandatorily, on completion of one years' satisfactory service.

18. Enrollment

Prescribed applications of the Gramin Dak Sevaks, who opted for coming under the new Service Discharge Benefit Scheme(SDBS), duly filled in the format **NL S1**, shall be submitted by the Sub Divisional Heads (IPO/IRM/ASPO/ASRM) to head of the relevant Postal Division for further verification of the customer/applicants' details, necessary authentication and certification. The applications so received from the Gramin Dak Sevaks in Divisional Office (Postal) shall be entered in a register including requisite particulars of the GDS concerned, and after doing the needful, be sent to the concerned **Facilitation Center** of the Central Record Keeping Agency (CRA) for registration, assigning and generation of Permanent Retirement Account Number (PRAN) and issue of digitized cards to the enrolled Gramin Dak Sevaks.

19. Digitised Account Cards

The CRA, "on receipt of the applications from the Collection Centres (CC)", shall enroll the applicant GDS under the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS), issue digitized cards for each enrolled GDS and send the same to the Collection Centre, duly entered in a list containing particulars including PRAN of the concerned GDS, for their delivery to the GDS concerned and further necessary action in accordance with these regulations.

20. Nomination

- (a) The GDS subscribers shall have nomination facility under the SDBS scheme and suitable provision for the purpose has been made in the Relevant application form itself.
- (b) The GDS can also nominate a person to received the accumulations under the Scheme and/or change the nomination made under sub para (1) above, at any time during the currency of his account under the Scheme, in the prescribed proforma (**SDBS-7**).

21. Grievance Redressal

(a) In case of any kind of complaint or grievance against any of the authorities mentioned here in this scheme, the GDS concerned may give their complaints in writing to any of the authorities including CRA, who will redress his part of the grievance and forward copy/ies of the complaint received to the various authorities who are competent to redress the same at the earliest. The grievances of the subscribers shall normally be redressed within **7 days** on receipt. No complaint and/or grievance of the GDS in this regard should, however, remain unsettled for over a **month's** period, in any case.

(b) The Collection Centres (CC) shall log into the Central Grievance Management System (CGMS) of the CRA once a day and take printouts of the complaints/grievance, if any, pertaining to their Unit for

their speedy settlement by all concerned. The CC will be enabled by CRA to log into its CGMS suitably. Similar course of action shall be adopted by the AO in this regard.

(c) In the case of complaints received in CC., directly or through Sub Divisional Inspectors/ASPOs., the same shall be uploaded in the CGMS of CRA for their speedy settlement by lodging into it on a daily basis. The written complaints will be kept on record in a separate file and their settlement watched.

(d) The AO for its enrolled GDS beneficiary/subscriber can register grievances through the web interface. Alternatively, the subscriber can send grievances through other channels also. CRA would register all complaints received in physical form also.

(e) In case of any complaint(s) and/or grievances of the CCs, and AOs. towards CRA, the matter shall be taken up immediately by the CC/AO concerned with CRA for its settlement immediately. If the matter is not settled within a month's time, the same shall be reported to the Oversight Office (OO), i.e. Postal Directorate, immediately. The OO shall take up the matter at appropriate levels with the CRA, PFRDA, NPS Trust, etc., for an amicable solution to the problem in a reasonable time slot.

Part III - Accounting Procedure

22. Classification of Transactions

The transactions relating to the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS) shall be classified under the following Heads of Accounts:

(a) Government Contribution:

The amount of contribution payable by the Government/Department of Posts, shall be debited to the following Head of Account:

- **Major Head: 3201** – Postal Services Working Expenses
- **Sub-Major Head: 02** – Operation
- **Minor Head: 101** – Postal Services
- **Sub-Head: 01** – Operation
- **Detailed Head: 02** – Wages
- **Object Head: 02.00.04** – Contribution to Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS)

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** The Head of Account structure for GDS wages and contributions is subject to periodic review by the Controller General of Accounts. The classification above reflects the standard operating head for operational expenses.

(b) Transfer of Funds to Trustee Bank:

The amount of contribution payable to the Trustee Bank shall be credited to the following Head of Account before transfer:

- **Major Head: 8448** – Deposits of Local Funds
- **Sub-Major Head: 00**
- **Minor Head: 120** – Other Funds
- **Sub-Head: 12** – Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS)
- **Object Head: 00.01** – Contribution

(c) Settlement of Claims/Exit:

The payments made to the beneficiaries/subscribers at the time of exit/death shall be debited to the Head of Account mentioned in **(b)** above.

(d) Miscellaneous:

Any other transaction, not covered above, shall be classified under the Head of Account decided by the Department in consultation with the Controller General of Accounts (CGA) / Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India.

23. Banking Arrangements

(a) The banking arrangements for the transfer of funds from the Department to the Trustee Bank and vice versa shall be made by the Department in consultation with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Trustee Bank appointed by the PFRDA.

(b) The Aggregator-cum-Accounts Offices (AO) shall maintain a separate Bank Account for the SDDBS in the designated branch of the Trustee Bank for the purpose of remittance of contributions and receipt of funds for settlement of claims.

(c) The balances in the Bank Account shall be reconciled with the books of accounts of the AO on a monthly basis.

Part IV - Forms and Schedules

The following Forms are prescribed for use under the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS):

List of Forms

1. **SDBS-1:** Application for Enrollment under Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS).
2. **SDBS-2:** Register of Applications for Enrollment under SDBS (to be maintained by Collection Centre).
3. **SDBS-3:** List of GDS Enrolled under SDBS (to be sent by Collection Centre to HPO/HRO/AO).
4. **SDBS-4:** Monthly Subscription List (to be prepared by HPO/HRO).
5. **SDBS-5:** Consolidated List of Subscriptions (to be prepared by AO).
6. **SDBS-6:** Application for Withdrawal/Exit from SDBS (Superannuation/ Premature/ Resignation/ Death).
7. **SDBS-7:** Nomination/Change of Nomination Form.
8. **SDBS-8:** Option Form for Existing Gramin Dak Sevaks (to switch over to SDBS or continue in Severance Amount Scheme).

□ **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** The content and layout of these forms are standardized by the PFRDA/NPS Trust and the Department of Posts. Electronic versions (e-Forms) are increasingly used on the CRA platform for processing.

Form Specifications**SDBS-1: Application for Enrollment**

- **Personal Details:** Name, Gender, Date of Birth, Father's/Husband's Name.
- **Official Details:** Designation, Office of Working, Date of Engagement, TRCA Slab.
- **Nomination Details:** Name of Nominee, Relationship, Date of Birth of Nominee, Percentage of Share.
- **Bank Details:** Savings Bank Account Number, Name of Post Office/Bank, Branch Code/IFSC.
- **Declaration:** Certification by the GDS regarding correctness of information and adherence to scheme rules.
- **Verification:** Certificate by the Appointing Authority/Divisional Head.

SDBS-6: Application for Withdrawal

- **Reason for Withdrawal:** Superannuation / Premature Exit / Resignation / Death.
- **PRAN:** Permanent Retirement Account Number.
- **Accumulation Details:** Total Corpus available.
- **Annuity Choice:** Percentage to be annuitized (Minimum 40% for normal exit, 80% for premature/resignation).
- **Lump Sum:** Percentage to be withdrawn as lump sum.
- **Annuity Service Provider (ASP):** Name of the Insurance Company selected.
- **Bank Details for Lump Sum:** Account Number, Bank Name, IFSC.

SDBS-8: Option Form

- **Declaration:** "I [Name], working as [Designation] at [Office], do hereby OPT to:"
 - **Option 1:** Join the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme (SDBS).
 - **Option 2:** Remain in the existing Severance Amount Scheme.
- **Undertaking:** "I understand that the option once exercised is final."

Clarifications and Miscellaneous**24. Power to Relax**

Where the Department of Posts is satisfied that the operation of any of the provisions of these regulations causes undue hardship in any particular case, the Department may, by order, for reasons to be recorded in writing, relax the requirements of that provision in a manner not inconsistent with the basic structure of the scheme.

25. Interpretation

If any question arises relating to the interpretation of these regulations, it shall be referred to the Director General (Posts) whose decision thereon shall be final.

26. Savings

Nothing in these regulations shall affect the right of the Government to modify, amend or repeal the scheme or any part thereof, from time to time.